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Vince Giordano

Vince Giordano was born on March 11, 1952 in Brooklyn. He directs the Nighthawks, where he switches between string bass, tuba and bass saxophone, and offers the occasional vocal. He has become the premier performer of 1920s and 30s jazz and popular music and has contributed music for films by Woody Allen and Martin Scorcese.

Vince was interviewed in New York City on January 11, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are in Manhattan filming for the Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have Vince Giordano here with me today. And thanks for making the trip.

VG: Thanks for having me.

MR: I understand you had a little eye surgery?

VG: A little eye surgery, I'll just give you — I'm not this cool character here, I'm a traditional jazz musician but I think I would probably look better this way.

MR: Yeah. Well I am familiar with your music. I like to think of you as Mr. Low End.

VG: Yeah.

MR: Why did you gravitate towards — you don't really look like a tuba player, or at least the junior high school tuba player.

VG: Well when I started I did. I originally started as a violinist and that was the instrument that I thought was going to be playing and I got hooked up with it. And I had a very bad teacher. And all the string students left. We couldn't take anymore. She was out of her mind. And in the seventh grade, it was a junior-senior high school, I went to the band director and I said I want to play an instrument, you know, I really have this interest. Because I'd been listening to music since I'm five. And I want to play the trumpet, the trombone, the clarinet, something like that. And he said we have too many of those kids, what we really need is a tuba player, because our tuba player is graduating next year and we have no one to hold down this chair. So he brought me in the room and cleaned out an old mouthpiece. I made a noise and he said, "you sound great" and promptly gave me a tuba to take home that day. And I was a very hefty kid. I love to eat and I'm a foodaholic. And that's why I wear black. And forever I was Tubby the Tuba.

MR: Oh.

VG: Yeah. That's okay. It's all right.

MR: Well you had an identity, and you do become a valuable person if — you know there's

VG: Absolutely. I wish I had a quarter for everyone that said if you would have taken the flute you wouldn't have to be schlepping all that equipment. I said if I played the flute I wouldn't be doing this job.

MR: Right.

VG: Like Ty Cobb, hit 'em where they ain't. You know, play the instruments that you can get called to do.

MR: Well I'm curious as to what — in your childhood or teen years or something — turned you on to the music from the twenties and thirties?

VG: I actually started when I was like five years old. I was born in Brooklyn and raised out in Smithtown, Long Island. And my grandparents remained in Brooklyn and every holiday we would come and do holiday things — whether it was Mother's Day, Thanksgiving, birthdays, Christmas, all that stuff. And they used to have a lot of parties in the twenties and thirties, family gatherings, where people brought old records, old phonograph records. They were married in 1922. And one day my grandmother points to this old victrola and shows me how to wind it up, and there was this array — there was like two thousand old records, everything from Grand Opera to novelty singers of the time, of the twenties, to an actual Louis Armstrong Okeh and a King Oliver Brunswick. So I would just be enthralled about winding up the machine and actually help produce this music by putting it on. And growing up in those years there was these wonderful hits like "How Much is that Doggie in the Window" and "Oh My Papa." And Lord, even as a kid, I said this is really corny stuff, it really is. And what I was hearing on these old discs was this great energy and this great vitality that I did not hear at the popular music of my time, the mid-fifties. And also coming home after school everyday you could still turn on your T.V. and see Laurel & Hardy, you could see the "Our Gang," "The Little Rascals" and the old black and white cartoons, which had elements of 1920s and early 30s jazz in it. This was still part of it. And those were my reinforcements. Like wow, there's my music so to speak. And I know I was this weird kid. Because everyone else was keeping up in the times and I would just be constantly drawn to searching out what I could find out about this music. And even watching T.V. shows like Joe Franklin, who was a fellow here in New York who is still around, and Max Morath. These would also be people who said yes this is old stuff but it's classic stuff, it's great stuff.

MR: And it was pop music at the time, right? Or not?

VG: Uh the pop music that I was listening to from the twenties, yeah it was pop and jazz.

MR: But your grandparents would have listened to that as popular music.

VG: Oh yes sure. Yeah. Well jazz in the 1920s was popular music. It was the Jazz Age so to speak and not everyone really knew what jazz was and called it a lot of different things. It

was probably — the twenties and thirties was really so great that the majority of the people would appreciate this new music.

MR: Did you start listening to it and sort of analyzing what you were hearing? You know, what kind of — was it a string bass, was this a — you know, what's the instrumentation here? When did that come about for you?

VG: Well on the early jazz recordings that my grandmother had there was definitely this sound that instrumentalists produced in those days that was a lost language as far as the fifties were concerned, particularly the way the saxophones would have that kind of little vibrato, that little moan, either hearing King Oliver or Louis Armstrong or some of the novelty cornetists. They had that kind of, you know, agitated vibrato. And there was a definite push on the downbeat, to get the thing going, and then this afterbeat. So here's this — I just took it all in, that this was something that I could not experience in my generation. It was something special about this music. And no one told me this, I found it and it was my music. I was just totally drawn to it.

MR: Were you able to enlist any of your friends?

VG: No. No. They would come over and — "don't play that stuff, don't play that stuff." They couldn't understand me for anything. That's fine. I chose the other path as the poet said. The one fateful day that really got me thinking about pursuing a career in this music was I was playing one of my old recordings and I had my tuba home, and I listened to it and I decided to try to play along with the recording. And I was maybe 12 years old. I could feel the beat but I really didn't have enough musicality to understand chord changes and I was just a beginner. I would kind of sync up but not really know what to do. And that magic moment was the time when I said I want to do something with this older music today in my generation. And that's when I started to seek out a place out on Long Island that had a live music policy, particularly older music that I could study, early popular music of the twenties and sometimes some jazz involved, and just basically get into the professional music world. I joined the union, I schlepped a tuba and later a string bass up two flights of stairs after the union fellow says, "why did you bring all this here? Did you bring your money?" That's all he wanted. He didn't care if I could play or not.

MR: I've heard variations on that story. That's so funny. Derek Smith, the piano player, they took him in a room and they said, "what is that?" He said, "what do you mean?" He says, "what is that?" He says, "it's a piano." He says, "you're in."

VG: Exactly. Oh it was some wild times.

MR: Jeepers. So going from hearing these tunes to actually trying to play them, you have to enlist some people to play with. Do you find people who are already playing and trying to get in with them.

VG: Yeah. Absolutely. I started out with this basically, for lack of better words, a banjo band and they used to have a lot of those banjo parlors in the world at that time, the sixties I guess, and tons of banjo players and a bass player of sort and they were so happy to see me that I was a young fellow and I would be interested in trying to learn tunes and learn chord changes. And you know, I made mistakes and there were a lot of musicians in there who weren't that great, but you'd try to find which musician is the better one. And then eventually one fellow came to me and said, "hey you want to do a gig?" "A gig, sure." And so my dad used to take me around, because I was too young to drive, and eventually I would meet musicians who were older, like 17 or 18, you know these were older guys. And they were able to pick me up and bring me to the gigs. And since I was this tall and a kind of heavy fellow, I was never carded or questioned. I seemed to look old enough to be part of the night life.

MR: Do you remember what the first dollar amount that you ever made was?

VG: As a professional musician I think it was twenty dollars for the evening, plus a meal.

MR: That's not too bad.

VG: It's not too bad. It's not too bad today.

MR: I know, it felt pretty good at that time.

VG: I mean I think the music business is the only business that the musicians' rates are either the same or worse than they were thirty years ago. It's the truth. It's a very sad commentary. But anyway.

MR: Well I think we'll get there, because I do want to talk about that. And you were in the military for a while. Was that by choice?

VG: Yes.

MR: It had to be.

VG: Yeah. I was in high school and I started out as a good student in the early days, and then I got into music. I was playing anytime I could, concert bands, marching bands, my occasional gig with these traditional jazz bands. And my grades just went [gestures]. And the Vietnam was war on. And my dad was kind of getting worried. He said, "you don't have a good enough average to go to college." And I'd rather not see you go over there. So we looked around and the Navy had a good music program. And we drove down there with all my stuff and I took the audition and the fellow said yeah. Of course I was studying privately. I wanted to be a concert tubist for a brief moment. And get through high school, we'll put you through boot camp and put you in one of the Navy bands. And I did it.

MR: You survived boot camp and all that.

VG: Yeah. It was great. I lost about 60 pounds in boot camp so that was great. And I got my

MR: And so in the military band, are you looking for people who have a like mind hoping that you might get some converts?

VG: Yeah. I only had one fellow that really wanted to play early jazz. He was a guitarist but he played a little cornet. And I was playing banjo in the band also, tuba, electric bass and banjo. And we would jam together and he got to use his cornet chops. But none of the other fellows really could see what I was doing at all. They would just kind of, you know, roll their eyes and raise their eyebrows to anyone that was interested in any kind of interest in this early archaic music. And I said, again, no problem.

MR: "Archaic" is an interesting word. Part of it I think, do people have a hard time with the fidelity of it?

VG: Correct.

MR: You know, that sort of ancient delivery system. Did it help at all when things started being reissued on CD or remastered?

VG: Well in those Navy days —

MR: That was pre-CD.

VG: Yeah that was pre-CD, that was still LPs and cassettes and all that stuff. You know I still get a lot of negative comments about what I'm doing. And I don't have any problem with music or jazz going as far as you want it to go, but not to just abandon or throw out some of the early styles. I mean we still play Mozart, Brahms and Beethoven along with Philip Glass and who everyone else say is contemporary, I don't know, I don't keep up with everybody just for a name. And they all should survive. But not to say well we shouldn't listen to these early classical masters, you know. And there's some people who take me to task for that.

MR: Is there — how do I put this? Is that music art to you?

VG: Oh yeah.

MR: Okay so why — do you think that some people are willing to call John Coltrane's music a very high art form?

VG: Yes.

MR: But the music of, you know Goldkette —

VG: Yeah, or Jelly Roll Morton. Because I think it's the hip thing to do. You know there's not too many hip folks that are probably going to want to listen to some ancient acoustic recording or a recording that's three minutes long or a recording that musicians had to work in a certain framework. You know there wasn't much freedom on a jazz recording in 1927 than there was in 1957. And it is what it is. You know there's no great dissonances in Mozart and it's beautiful the way it is. And your early automobiles weren't great, they didn't have air conditioning or sound systems or 120 miles an hour,

early jazz masters were the pioneers. Before them, for the most part, there was no jazz. You know there were people doing classical music and folk music and pop music and here was these fellows and gals saying I'm creating a new language and this is great. Of course not everything that came from those times or those musicians is golden, I understand that. But there's a lot of great stuff there.

MR: And for your ears is there a discernable difference between the black bands and the white bands going back as far as you do?

VG: Yeah, oh yeah. I think they basically were fulfilling the same obligation of dance music, popular music. I think the black bands really did have a little bit more freedom in playing jazz than the white musicians. A lot of the white musicians, of course you know, respected and learned about jazz from their black musician friends, the countless stories of the Austin High Gang fellows going down to hear King Oliver and buying the recordings and studying and copying. And I think there was a lot of cross pollenization. A lot of bands and musicians worked together, you know, and which were learning from each other. It was a great learning session. But yet there was a difference.

MR: Tell me about how The Nighthawks came about.

VG: Well I was in Italy playing with a little jazz band over there and I got a postcard from a friend of mine and he says, "you better get back to the States because there's a fellow here, a radio DJ by the name of Rich Connerty, who's putting together a band to play old Paul Whiteman arrangements." So I said wow that's pretty interesting. So I get back to the States after the gig is over, and I look him up, and sure enough he got Xeroxes from Williams College collection of the Paul Whiteman scores and just announced over the radio that he was putting a band together to read these things down. Now Rich is a wonderful guy but he's not a musician, and of course there's no funding, there's no gig in sight, there's just rehearsal of 1920s music. And it's a big ensemble, it's like sometimes some of these things are 22 pieces. So I show up and there's a couple of saxophones, a trumpet, you know there's no strings. So we're trying to read these things down and there's just too much missing. It's sort of like running an automobile with three of the tires on. And we're all counting measures. And so we did this for a couple of weeks, and I said, "Rich, I have these arrangements that are better at smaller ensembles" what they call stock arrangements. And I brought those. And those were more workable to at least get a sound together. And we started to look in the musician's book to see who was around from the 1920s and 30s to try to play in this band. And we got all kinds of wonderful players who hadn't been called in years, some guys that were in the musicians' book but hadn't owned an instrument in years, so that was kind of sad. And we put this little repertory band together. And eventually he got busy with his radio work, he went to

MR: And that evolved into a group that you could gig with?

VG: Yeah. A lot of times, the older fellows, they didn't want to travel. We had Clarence Hutchenrider from the Casa Loma band, and Jimmy Maxwell who played with Benny Goodman, Bernie Privin who was with Artie Shaw, Carmen Mastren who played guitar with Tommy Dorsey. And they — Dill Jones, who wasn't as old as those fellows but still a veteran, on great piano. And many, many musicians, Bobby Prane, we had Herbie "Cat" Collins, a great drummer from the 1930s who played with a lot of the black bands, and there was a constant change because guys would be enthusiastic and then kind of — Al Gallodoro played lead alto for a while with us. So you know, we tried to put as many of these great musicians to work, even though there wasn't much work and the money wasn't that good.

MR: You know Al is still playing?

VG: Yes, yeah. He's amazing.

MR: Yeah. Tell me about the Schillinger Method with Bill Challis.

VG: With Bill Challis, yeah. Well joining the union, I got the union directory. And I had been reading this book called "Jazz: the New York Scene" by Charters and Kunstadt. I love that book and it's a wonderful book. And they mention Bill Challis a few times and I just happened to be flipping in the arranger section and I see William Challis in Massapequa, Long Island. I'm in Smithtown. And I wrote him a letter and I said I'd love to study with you. And he said fine. And my dad, again, takes me out there, because I'm still this teenager. And my dream with Bill Challis was to have a nice manuscript paper and some pencil and just start writing or start analyzing his work, whatever. But he stopped that right from the beginning. He says, "no, I want you to learn the Schillinger Method." He said, "in the 1930s I was there with George Gershwin two rows over, and we had Glenn Miller, and so many musicians. They were studying this way of making their music fresh and they could per"— what's the word here — I just lost the name of what we used to talk about — well we went through this stuff and it was about a year and a half. And I was still in high school and trying to do my grades and my gigs and we'd be there with graph paper and we really never got into the music. The best part of my sessions with Bill Challis was the two hours after where I used to talk with him. And sometimes the old drummer Chauncey Morehouse from the Jean Goldkette band was there and in fact one day I came about 15 minutes early and Chauncey was there and Bill and they were playing four hands at the piano, and they were trying to write a rock song called "Swamp Boogie." And I was this young teenager and they said, "hey kid, what do you think about this?" And I said, "well guys I really don't know much about Rock & Roll. Let's talk about Frankie Trumbauer and Bix again." But it was kind of sad because really time had

left, it had passed these fellows by. You know they just were looking for a gig and hoping to write a song, and that's a long winded story about the Schillinger Method.

MR: No I like to hear stuff like that. I mean how old would they have been at that time?

VG: In their seventies.

MR: Were they still — after their heyday did they stay in music?

VG: Well Chauncey played a little bit of bass drum in the Goldman concert band. His eyesight was pretty bad and he really wasn't up to studio work anymore, his chops just weren't there. Bill really wasn't doing anything. He got an occasional call from Manhattan Transfer to write a few charts for them and he called me up and said, "I've got this young group they want me to recreate some Goldkette things. And I didn't have the heart to tell him it wasn't my arrangements, it was Don Murray's arrangements, so I took the gig." And you know Bill, pretty much after Eddie Fisher — he did all Eddie Fisher's arrangements — he really wasn't used anymore. Again, they just went for the younger folks and he just lived out there in Long Island with his sister and I guess had Social Security and that was it.

MR: Yeah. He wasn't the last of the Goldkettes, I think Spiegel might have been, or Spiegel was the last fellow apparently to play with Bix.

VG: Oh right.

MR: I believe he was. Was Bix Beiderbecke a big sort of, influence, a love for you?

VG: Oh yeah. Bix was one of my heroes. We almost share the same birthday. He is March 10 and I am March 11, and that's about where the similarity is, because he had all the talent. And of course hanging with Bill he told me a lot of stuff about Bix and how much they really loved working together and they were in admiration of each other where Bix had all this talent that was just flowing like a mineral spring, and Bill could write it all down, what he could grab, whether it was his jazz phrasing or his modern piano pieces. And Bill really tried to help Bix as much as he could. And it just wasn't in the cards. He just had this horrible short life.

MR: Yeah. He was a meteor for sure.

VG: Yeah. But I find a lot of inspiration, well, from a lot of those musicians: Bix, Coleman Hawkins, of course Armstrong, Henry "Red" Allen. People ask me what's my favorite band or what's my favorite musician, I can't tell you. It's like endless. There's an endless variety that I keep going to. And it keeps my life interesting that way.

MR: What's the most, in your LP or CD collection, what's the most recent thing that you can relate to?

VG: Hmm. The most recent thing that I can relate to.

MR: Or that you enjoy listening to.

VG: I'm trying to think. You know I've bought a few and I think probably this one Henry "Red" Allen, it's not the most recent thing but I keep going back to these different takes of the Henry "Red" Allen Orchestra that came together in the late twenties, it was really the Luis Russell Band but he fronted it and made these wonderful Victor sides. And there were so many takes, and I grew up with the LP version. And it's a wonderful thing when you just hear one take and it's in your mind, and then all of a sudden you hear this other take out of the blue and whoa, it just makes me fall out of my chair when I hear what these guys were doing from take to take. So those are real wonderful revelations for me. I never tire listening to that stuff.

MR: Is the way those fellows played teachable do you think?

VG: I think so. I think it is. I think it's like a language, it's like learning a foreign language. But you have to have a willing student and someone who is not afraid of being criticized about learning that style. And a lot of young people today, you know, they want to be with it, and they want to be where the rest of their musicians are thinking. And if you want to stray a little bit out of that it's really hard. I can tell youth from that being from my youth. I think it's a lot possibly easier today. I think what Wynton is doing with his jazz education and his spreading the Gospel, saying that this music is great music, it's classic music. And it's part of jazz and it's all related. And that's been very helpful. That's been very helpful. You know you've got a major figure, you've got a wonderful forum, the Jazz at Lincoln Center, so that gives a lot of credibility to it. You know in my day, it's a bar here, a gin mill here, you know working for the door and that kind of stuff. And how much can you influence young kids?

MR: It's interesting, tomorrow morning there's a panel entitled "Trad Jazz, Alive and Well." Should be an interesting conversation.

VG: Wow. What time is that? Maybe I'll —

MR: It's 9 o'clock.

VG: Oh that's early enough.

MR: Yeah.

VG: All right. Well I've got a doctor's appointment at one, maybe I'll come by. Do you know who's on the panel?

MR: You should try. Mat Domber —

VG: Good, good.

MR: Leslie Johnson.

VG: Oh great.

MR: And Wycliffe Gordon.

VG: Excellent.

VG: John Schoup.

MR: He had something to do with, oh I won't be able to think of it now, but I hope to attend and see what they have to say, because what's sort of ironic about it, if you look at the huge schedule of what goes on here, there's not much trad jazz to be found. Not only in the bands they have playing but also any other forums they're talking about. So I'm not sure what that means. But I don't think people, they have a harder time teaching people to play that because it's not codified as much you know. Like gee we can't use a Mixolydian scale in this song.

VG: Most definitely.

MR: I mean it's hard to teach people to play melodies, right?

VG: Correct.

MR: To improvise melodies?

VG: Yeah, a lot of young people, they want to get up there and play a million notes and play high and fast and all that stuff, which is good, but you have to start someplace. It's sort of like this glass of water here you know? Mr. Morton, Jelly Roll Morton said if you've got a half a glass of water you can go up. But if you start with a full glass, you can't go any further, you're just going to go all over. And a lot of these kids want to go with a full glass and they blow themselves out. And playing the melody is just a wonderful way to introduce the tune, it's a little tip of the hat to the composers who originally — and that's what he did — and now what do you want to do with this? And it's a great contrast, it's a great show. And I think that's one of the reasons I love the older forms of jazz because they would work within that format, stating the melody and then creating your own melody.

MR: Is it a hurdle for trad jazz to be heard and sort of accepted because it's not really an opportunity for new compositions?

VG: Well no. There's been some people who have taken a trad jazz approach to like bebop. There is a wonderful band that used to be in Paris. The musicians are all alive, but they're not playing anymore, called the Anachronic Jazz Band. And they would take these bebop tunes and make them sound like King Oliver or Thelonious Monk or Charlie Parker. It was amazing. I was totally knocked out on their imagination and how to do this. I think there can be musicians today who can still write in a style of Jelly Roll Morton or in a style of King Oliver or Bix Beiderbecke and still be true to that idiom. Not as many would want to do that these days unfortunately.

MR: There was an interesting entry about you, I forget where I saw it, it said that you retired in 1996.

VG: Yeah. Yeah I hung it up for a while.

VG: I took a gig at a record company, in fact Joe Muranyi was here and it was the same company, it was the RCA Victor Company. And it was, in my time, known as BMG. Burtlesman Music Company. And I worked in the archive, which was a wonderful gig. And I had kind of had enough. I tried to run everything by myself, it's really hard.

MR: Oh yeah.

VG: You've got so many things to contend with. And it was time.

MR: If you had a Monday night with your band, did you have trouble because some of your musicians might have got a call for a better paying gig or something and get a phone call and like okay, now I've got to fill this chair. That's very hard.

VG: It's very hard, it's part of the frustration. And you know, sometimes you might get a substitute and he might be, you know a nice fellow and a good musician, but not really the person to make this meal. I look at it like everyone's putting these ingredients into making this meal and if you don't have the right seasoning or the right combination it's not going to turn out as well as having the right person in there to give you the feel or give you the idiom or the understanding of what the band is about.

MR: Are you kind of, do you feel like you're in the — at least in the circle — or you're known for having this knowledge and this ability in this idiom so when things come up like "The Aviator" that you do get those calls?

VG: Well yeah, in a way I'm very fortunate to be associated with this genre of music and you would think being in New York there's not that much film work to be done and I don't know for some reason some of the cards were in the right place for once in my life, where they chose to do these period films in New York working for Dick Hyman, who was the musical director for so many of the Woody Allen films, and Woody has a passion for the older music, and Dick says, "yeah, let's get Vince, he can bring three of his instruments and really loves playing this music too." I mean you can get a lot of players in there who will do the gig, but I really love doing it. That's the truth.

MR: Do you believe in reincarnation?

VG: Well in myself, yeah, maybe a little bit. I don't fantasize about it but I have no idea why I have this passion and love for these things and just this unquenchable thirst to find as much as I can about the musicians who put it all together.

MR: It's interesting to speculate. Because I sometimes feel like I was born too late. Maybe not too late as you might have been born too late, but I was into the swing era a great deal. I wonder what it would have been like to live through that.

VG: Um hum. Well it was rough. Talking to all these musicians and reading their stories of fellows I didn't get a chance to meet, the fellows talked about their life on the road and the horrible conditions, the terrible food. I mean today musicians have it easy, you know,

MR: That's a great statement. When they do get the work it's easier.

VG: Oh yeah. I mean they've got an air conditioned place or a heated place, the piano is basically in tune if it's not they'll bring in an electric keyboard or whatever. The accommodations, the buses, and not to speak of all the horrendous racial stuff that went on in the south with black musicians. It was just awful. I don't know how guys did it. And it makes me even more appreciative of what these musicians did with all those hardships.

MR: The fellows that I've been able to talk to from that era just have an awful lot of love for one another. Somehow the music sustained them, made all that stuff, you know they dealt with it somehow.

VG: Yeah. There was this camaraderie, they were all in it together.

MR: Would a place like the Blue Note ever book a band like The Nighthawks?

VG: I'd like them to do that but we've succeeded at Iridium, which was known for more modern jazz. We'd been doing some kind of irregular things at the Iridium if you want to say that, and it's been very rewarding to play in a nice place like that with an actual fantastic Steinway piano that works, and music stands and lights that are already there and that wonderful sound system and a fellow on the sound board. To me this is a rarity these days for what I've been through and my little hardships of putting the band in clubs around New York in the last 30 years.

MR: And I don't know if this is a good question or not. Trad jazz and classic jazz — is there a difference for you?

VG: There shouldn't be. I mean trad jazz to a lot of people is a little bit more freer and as far as less attention to details as I think classic jazz is. Classic jazz to me is a real study of the music and whether it's recreating certain recordings and the solos and analyzing it. To me the trad jazz idea is let's get together and have a good time and just blow and we're not going to be too picky.

MR: Oh. Well what would you call a Kenny Davern record?

VG: Wonderful.

MR: Absolutely.

VG: That's number one. You know I tried to hire Kenny Davern one time when he lived in New Jersey to do a master class. I said Kenny Davern — and we worked together — and I said just bring your clarinet and you, I'll bring all the recordings, whatever you want to do, and I'll pay you as much as you want, as long as it's not a million dollars, to play for my guys. Because what you bring to this music, whether it's a slow tempo or a fast tempo, the pot is always boiling. There's this heat, there's this energy. And he was one of the true fellows in my lifetime who really understood the early guys. Him and this fellow

They're old enough but they went and saw Garvin Bushell, they went and saw the real guys from the twenties. They were there and worked alongside of them. And some of that was rubbed off. The newer musicians don't have that luxury.

MR: Yeah. They don't have the opportunity for hero worship almost.

VG: Yeah.

MR: I mean that's what Kenny, when he talked about Adrian Rollini and hearing Pee Wee Russell, that changed his life you know.

VG: To be in the flesh. I think you know there's a lot of musicians today that they look at these things as historical things but there's no one-on-one, there's no contact. It's — all right some of the films have been coming out and you can go on YouTube and watch an occasional great jazz performance, but it's not the same as going to a club and seeing them, and aww damn it, I played that solo bad, or spit on the floor or spill over a drink or whatever. I mean these guys were gods. And those three aforementioned reed players of my time, they were able to be part of that.

MR: Kenny had a certain way of articulating too on the clarinet that was very unique, like a legato tongue you know but it lent a real direction to what he was playing or something. I just was surprised by — because he could be, his personality, he could be I don't know, fill in the blank.

VG: Yes.

MR: But the melodies he came up with just somehow seemed to disconnect to the kind of person you would think he was unless you got to really know him.

VG: Yeah. Oh he was definitely in another world when he played and that was the true spirit and genius of the guy through that. We did one performance backing him up at Dick Wellstood's funeral and he played the J.C. Johnson tune called "Traveling All Alone." And even now it still grabs me, just thinking about it, and the hair on the back of my neck —

MR: Well I got to play with him a couple of times up at Hamilton College and I'm telling you it was a high point of my life just about. I brought in a little, this will be like a drop the needle test.

VG: Oh wonderful, like a blindfold test, I've got my glasses on, good.

MR: Yes. This is a sunglasses test. Let's see if I got it up here.

[audio interlude]

MR: You might want to be careful what you say about who this is. I like it.

VG: Great stuff. Everybody's doing the right stuff. Good bass sax guy

MR: Any idea yet?

VG: No, no. Maybe Dick Sudhalter on trumpet?

VG: Is that me? I had no idea.

MR: That's interesting. See when I play things for people I don't really — I usually play their own things so I could have given you a clue. But that's with Keith Ingham and something on — I forget the record label — with Joe Boughton?

VG: Oh really, okay. I don't recognize my sound. I mean there was not enough in there, you know I was basically just keeping the time there. Wow okay. I survived my own blindfold test even though I don't know it was me.

MR: Well you did point out that it was a nice bass saxophone.

VG: One of the those European guys or something.

MR: Yeah. How did the bass saxophone come into your life?

VG: Well I — collecting recordings in my high school days and I did a lot of antique — in fact I worked in an antique shop along with a music shop. I mean I was just working all over the place. And I'd get first dibs on the recordings. And one day I get this 78 and I'm playing it and it's the California Ramblers. And I'm hearing this wild sound and Jesus it's some kind of bassoon or something. My high school still had those three speed turntables, those old, I forget what they called them. And I brought the record in and my band director says, "oh that's a bass sax." That's a bass sax, wow. I've got to find one of those. And so again my poor parents I dragged them all over Long Island. So many people, we showed up and of course it was a baritone sax. Many times it was a tenor and they said, "well gee whiz, it's big."

MR: Seems pretty big to me.

VG: Exactly. How big is big? So I finally found a fellow who — he was a string bass, tuba and bass sax — he was almost what I eventually became, and he had it in his attic and brought it out and it was completely — it was a silver sax at one point but it was completely black, like somebody spray painted it. Completely tarnished. And he sold it to me for 95 dollars. So I got it, I cleaned it up and brought it into the music store where I was working and it was part of my project to put it together and re-pad it. It wasn't a great horn but it was a good horn to start with. And I got to go out to meet with Art Rollini and sort of take a lesson with him. He lived out in Long Island, out in Shirley, and so I'm putting my horn together and I put my mouthpiece in and Art says, "well, there's your first mistake." I said, "what? What did I do?" Art says, "that's a bass saxophone mouthpiece." I says, "yes." He says, "Adrian never used that." And I, you know, I wanted to say well I wasn't around in 1921 when he picked it up. And Adrian used a baritone sax mouthpiece. And that was part of his punch and flexibility on the horn was doing that. And then I later got to meet Spencer Clark who replaced Adrian in the California Ramblers and of course heard stories about Joe Rushton and most of the jazz bass

bigger and bigger, it's getting closer to a bass mouthpiece, as I'm getting them made bigger, but it's much easier to find reeds and to control the horn. So that's pretty much how I got into it. And I would cut classes in high school and take lessons with the other guys who were saxophone players. The teacher wouldn't — he said you're busy enough with the tuba and the bass. So the kids taught me how to play the fingerings and stuff and I'm pretty much self-taught on the thing and I read it in treble clef and you know it's just a wonderful instrument.

MR: With the music on most of the arrangements that you play, are all the bass parts written out?

VG: Yes.

MR: Pretty precisely?

VG: Yeah. For the wind basses, for the tuba and the bass saxophone. For the string bass part, when it's more of a free thing for swing, we'll have chord changes in there. When you're talking with the wind bass, either the tuba or the bass sax, he's usually doubling the piano, and that reinforces, so you really want to have a precise bass part so that you don't have these clashes. Like I'll play the root and he'll play the fifth, or he'll play the fifth and I'll play the root. It gets a little muddy down there you know. When you've got higher instruments it's not that bad to have a little flavor of that sort. But you really want to lock it in with the same bass notes.

MR: Do you think that — this is an awful general question — when music moved from sort of two-beat into four-beat, how much was the string bass a role in that?

VG: Well you know I hear people phrasing in four, at least the horn, even with the two-beat feel going on. But I think when the musicians eventually got the idea and the feel of the pulsing four-beat they really didn't want to go back. And so the tuba can do that and in the early days of like John Kirby where he did play some four-beat on the tuba, it was too unwieldy. And so once the string bass got ahold of that sound, and it was time for a change. You know jazz is always evolving, and putting the banjo away and getting the guitar with a kind of a softer feel, you know it just was one of those progressions. And musicians were always looking for something new and to claim their own development in jazz I think.

MR: Here's a question that rarely works, okay? What was the worst gig you've ever played?

VG: Oh my. Oh that's easy. I wouldn't say my worst gig, one of my worst gigs, let's go like that. We got hired to do a New Year's Eve party out in New Jersey, oh maybe 15, 18 years ago or something like that. And I got there in time and the weather was nice, everything was going along fine. The people did not want any kind of swing or acoustic music whatsoever. They just hated it. So after like about 20 minutes comes sort of, "could

a DJ there. The DJ came on. The place was mobbed. So here it is, it's New Year's Eve and it's like about ten minutes before twelve, and the maitré d comes — you know we're not on, we've been on a break since like nine twenty. And so the guys are drinking, they're eating, they don't care. And the party planner, whatever, says, "do youze guys know the New Year's Eve song? The DJ doesn't have it." I said, "you mean 'Auld Lang Syne'? Yes we know that." So, "well could you play that, and then take a break?" "Okay." I said, "you have the check, now?" So we played "Auld Lang Syne," a couple of choruses, and back to Joe the DJ. And that was it. And it was one o'clock and guys I'm sorry, but it was just one of those things that people have certain likes and dislikes and it was one of those nights that we were definitely the wrong band for that party. And that's the way it goes.

MR: At least you got paid.

VG: Exactly.

MR: So it could have been somewhat worse. So right now, what do you do? Do you find it necessary to do other things with keeping the music alive as much as you can?

VG: Yeah. I freelance with other different groups, Marty Grosz occasionally calls me and John Booker. And we've driven to Cincinnati to play a gig, I mean that's as crazy it is, even though I live in New York — the capital of the world — doing the BMG gig was eight years and that was a neat little day gig and then working nights and weekends. At this point most of my bills are paid and I'm not working as much as I'd like to be working but like I said my big drive is to really try to get this idea of a club in New York happening.

MR: Yeah.

VG: And that's what I've been doing. You know I have enough jobs to keep me busy and keep the checks paid.

MR: I see you occasionally make the jazz party scene?

VG: Yeah, in Chautauqua and Atlanta, and I'm going out to Elkhart this year in 2007. So that should be a lot of fun.

MR: Did you ever make that — I just became aware of the annual Bix Beiderbecke festival in Davenport.

VG: Yeah. I've played it about three times at least. I got to play Bix's grave and some of the ballrooms that Bix worked like Bacall Ballroom, and some of the other little dance hall establishments that were around in Bix's time. And it's a lovely festival outside of the heat. It's in the summertime and the Midwest can be very unfriendly, particularly at these outdoor venues. The other little hassle getting into there — it's a small airport and they have these puddle jumper planes and when you play the bass sax or the other instruments

it's really hard to get your stuff in there. And the airlines and I are not on good terms these days.

MR: I can imagine.

VG: They've wrecked and destroyed and lost — temporarily thank goodness — my equipment and there's got to be a better way.

MR: What's with the aluminum bass?

VG: Oh the aluminum bass is a little bit of a — see I like to be a little bit of what we call show business, because the music that I love really needs all the attention it can get and if I can get someone to talk to me and be interested in what I'm doing it's a plus. I find I can pass out a card or get his or her card. I tried one at an antique shop, I was going through a bunch of stuff and I saw the bass in the corner and I — you know I don't need another bass, I have two basses as it is. I turned it over and I started to play and it was kind of a weird sound. And when I gave it a bang-bang-bang I said wait a minute, this is one of these aluminum basses. It was painted wood grain.

MR: Oh my goodness.

VG: And so many basses that you might have seen in pictures might have been aluminum basses. Pops Foster played one for a while, John Kirby did for a while, and there are different makes and different models and some are better than others. And I, just as a novelty I just stripped off all the paint so it's naked aluminum. And I get so many people who come to me and say, "what's with this?" And I say — oh and I have our violinist play a phono-fiddle, which is a violin with a horn, for occasional numbers. And again it's kind of a show biz thing and hopefully that we can get a few people on our side. And they say "why do you bring this bass?" And I say "well if I had a wooden bass you wouldn't —"

MR: Who would ask about it?

VG: Who would ask about it? You wouldn't ask me about it either.

MR: That's right. The only time I saw one, in an elementary school in Utica, New York, I saw one, and I didn't even know that they had existed. Interesting. Well you know show biz was part and parcel of the music back then right?

VG: Absolutely.

MR: So why not?

VG: Exactly. Yeah I have an old vintage microphone and the old drumset and the old banners and things like that, and bringing weird other instruments to the foray like a trombone megaphone that Spiegel showed me how to use.

MR: Oh, how sweet.

VG: Yeah. And I have a straight baritone sax, the only one in the world, that I got from Benny

MR: How long is that thing?

VG: It's almost six foot. And I have to stand up and play it, I put it on a stand. Benny Miroff was a small man. He had to stand on a stool. He made a Vitaphone short and there it is. So things like that, a little celeste you know.

MR: And when did you start — have you always been a singer?

VG: No. And you know I try my hand at singing you know. And there's better singers out there but to me I never want to get the audience too overwhelmed with too much singing or if people are singing, "oh why don't you use this person?" And this way if anybody complains about the singer it's just me, they can just complain. And I don't really do that much but I try to just put over a song here and there in the style of some of those so-called singing band leaders.

MR: Well you looked darned good in "The Aviator."

VG: Oh thanks. Well that was a lot of fun. Films are one way of turning people around. And with all these films that I've been associated with in the past twenty years or so I was always looking for another Sting movie. What "The Sting" did for Scott Joplin and Ragtime was fantastic. It took this music that really was in the background and young kids were learning "The Sting" which is really "The Entertainer." And we were always hoping for a successful film that would get kids interested in early jazz and some of this pop music, hut it hasn't happened yet, it hasn't happened.

MR: Well did we get you on your soapbox enough today?

VG: I think so. I think so.

MR: Have you ever considered not living in New York?

VG: No. No. New York is the capital of the world and the musicians are here. Last year our mayor said that 45 million tourists came to New York. There's your audience. I'm not saying that we need 45 million people in my club, in this club idea, but if we get one zillionth of a percentile, there's the place. And the next night there's another bunch of folks. I know it's expensive but if you have someone believe in what you do, as people have believed in opera and classical music or a certain hospital or a certain cause, anything is possible. You just have to have Mr. or Ms. Right there.

MR: Right. You've got to find that person.

VG: Yeah.

MR: What's a typical club date for a musician pay these days in New York?

VG: Uh for four hours generally anywhere between $250 to $350. Something like that, if it's in the area. More money if you're out of town and you've got to stay over and per diem for meals and things like that. It's really hard when a person that wants music at their party can hire a DJ and give four hours of music — continuous. I've been told many

MR: What started to irk me is when the DJs started referring to what they do as a gig. I said, "you don't have a gig."

VG: I know. And there's been some talk about the musician's union trying to get the DJ's to join them, which is really scary because it's like what are we representing here?

MR: That's pretty desperate.

VG: It really is. It's desperate times but it shouldn't be. There's enough folks out there that are looking for alternative music. When we play the Iridium we do get a bunch of college kids coming down or younger folks. It's not all gray or blue or non-hair, whatever you want to call it. There is enough folks that want to hear some alternative stuff and they want to hear some truthful music. And we're serving up the truth.

MR: All right. Sounds like a good way to wrap up.

VG: I think so.

MR: All right. Thanks for your time.

VG: Thank you so much for having me.